

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Will I be able to stay active in labor? Most women are able to remain active through labor and are encouraged to do so, perhaps using props such as a chair, beanbag, or birthing ball. Staying active can help since this can speed up labor, and changing your position can help you deal with labor pain. When you arrive at the hospital or birth center, discuss your birth plan with the doctor and inform her that you want to be as active as possible.

Will I lose control if I use hypnosis during my labor? No, you will simply feel deeply relaxed, but will still be in control and know what you are doing. Don't worry—self-hypnosis will help you be less anxious and frightened during your labor, which will help you to deal with labour pain.

I've had a previous Cesarean. Does this mean that I won't be able to labor in water this time? It depends on the procedures that your health-care provider follows for women who have already had a Cesarean. After a Cesarean, the doctors will want to monitor you and the baby either continuously or frequently during labor, because there is a very small chance that your uterus may rupture, which is often only detected through a change in the baby's heartbeat. But waterproof monitoring systems are widely available and many practices perform WBAC—water birth after Cesarean.

At what point can I get into the birthing pool? This is up to you. Relaxing in warm water is often suggested in the early stages of labor, as long as your contractions are progressing. You can sit in the warm water for 1½ to 2 hours for pain management, but then get out. Changing your environment helps keep your labor active.

MASSAGE AND TOUCH

Many women find massage helpful in labor to induce relaxation, bring about a sense of well-being, and alleviate pain. Your birth partner may find it relaxing and therapeutic too. Ideally, they will have had a chance to see massage techniques demonstrated in prenatal classes and to practice before labor. Massaging the lower back helps relieve pain in this area; head, neck, and shoulder massage is beneficial for relieving tension and fatigue.

The touch therapies shiatsu and acupressure can also help relieve pain and tension. They involve application of pressure to specific points to increase endorphin levels. You or your partner will need to learn the techniques from a trained practitioner. Ask your doctor whether they can put you in touch with a practitioner.